

In the weeks ahead

These tasks can be spread out over weeks. Let trusted people help you, and take them at your own pace.

Finances and paperwork

- Use certified death certificates to notify banks, credit unions and insurers, so your loved one's accounts are protected.
- Contact life insurance companies and any pension provider.
- Ask the Social Security office about survivor benefits for you or for dependent children.
- Keep up with important bills, such as mortgage, taxes and home insurance.

Home and family

- Arrange care for dependents and pets.
- Redirect mail, and update utility, phone and internet accounts.
- Cancel subscriptions and memberships when you are ready.
- Notify schools and your loved one's faith community, if that applies.

Requesting medical records

Records of a loved one who has died require a signed authorization and a letter of authority from the Probate Court. Email

HFHSMedicalRecords@HFHS.org or fax **313-916-3917**.

You are not alone

Grief support at Henry Ford Health is open to the whole community, whether or not your loved one was in our care.

Grief support at Henry Ford Health

Grief support groups & newsletter

In person and online, plus the monthly *Bereavement News*, through Henry Ford Hospice • **586-276-9570**

SandCastles, for children and teens

Peer grief support for ages 3–18 and their families • **313-771-7005** • sandcastles@hfhs.org

Spiritual care

Our chaplains support people of every faith, and of none. Ask any staff member, any hour.

More support, any time

Call or text 988, Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, 24/7
Dial 2-1-1, free help finding services across Michigan



Grief support & newsletter

henryford.com/services/at-home/hospice/support



SandCastles

aboutsandcastles.org

Developed by the Central Autopsy Service • An initiative led by **Pamela Holmes-Hill & Troy Shaffer** • Design & content by **Omar Z. Baba, MD**

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HEALTH**

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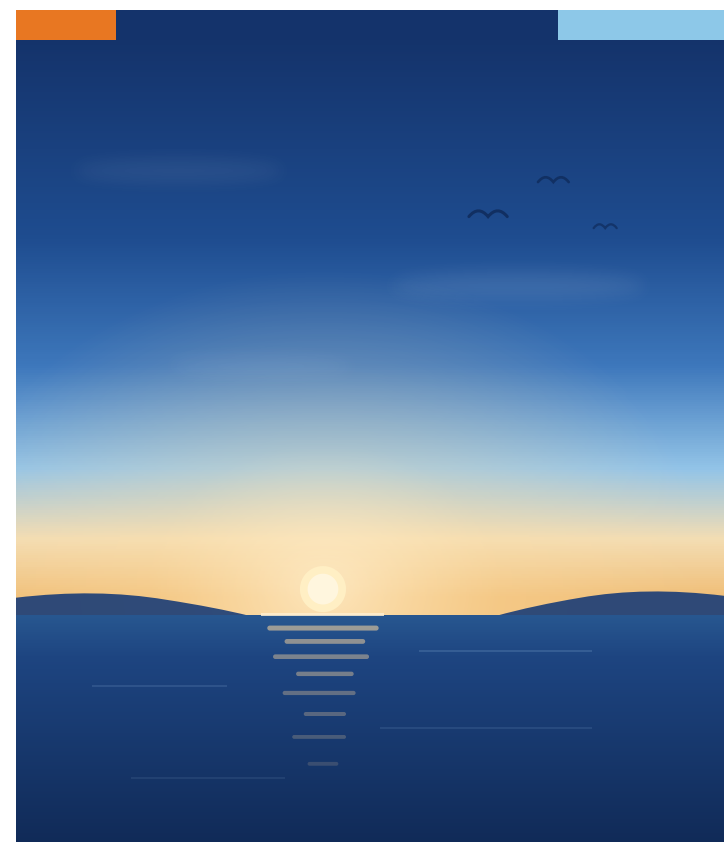
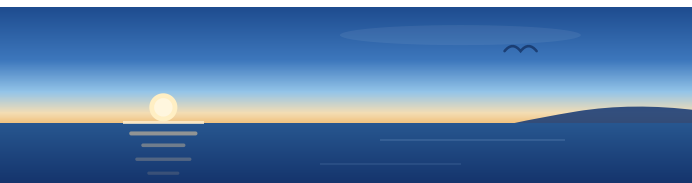
**HENRY
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HEALTH**

Henry Ford Hospital

After the Death of a Loved One

**Support, next steps and resources for
you and your family.**

Central Autopsy Service • Department of Pathology &
Laboratory Medicine



We are deeply sorry for your loss

The death of someone you love can feel overwhelming. There is no right way to grieve and no set timeline. Whatever you are feeling right now is a normal response to loss.

Along with grief, there are often decisions to make and details to handle. This guide walks you through them one step at a time. You do not have to do everything today, and you do not have to do it alone.

If you have questions at any time, please ask any member of your care team. We are here for you.

In the first few days: caring for yourself

- Let others help. Sharing tasks lightens your load, and it often comforts them, too.
- Try to eat regular meals and rest, even when sleep is hard.
- Keep taking any medications prescribed for you.
- Ask someone to drive you to appointments, or to sit with you while you make calls.
- Set aside time to grieve. Tears, numbness, anger and even relief are all normal.

When to seek help right away

If you have thoughts of harming yourself, or you feel unable to care for yourself or for those who depend on you, help is available right now.

Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, 24/7), call your doctor, or go to the nearest emergency room.

When an autopsy or the medical examiner is involved

What is an autopsy?

An autopsy is a careful medical examination performed by a specially trained doctor called a pathologist. It can help answer questions about an illness or the cause of death. Your loved one is treated with dignity, care and respect at every step. Families may also request an autopsy; your care team can tell you how.

When is the medical examiner involved?

Michigan law requires certain deaths to be reported to the county medical examiner, including deaths from an accidental injury or during a medical procedure. When this applies, Henry Ford Health contacts the medical examiner, who decides whether an autopsy is required. If it is, we will let you know.

Wayne County	313-833-2504
Oakland County	248-858-4044
Macomb County	586-469-5214

What should I expect?

- In most cases, an autopsy does not delay funeral plans and does not prevent a viewing.
- Your loved one is usually in the care of your funeral home within a few days.
- Results take time, often several weeks. We will share them with you and answer your questions in plain language.
- Questions at any time? Ask your care team to connect you with our Autopsy Service.

Practical matters

Working with a funeral home

- Tell hospital staff which funeral home you have chosen, so we can arrange your loved one's transfer.
- Bring a family member or trusted friend with you to the funeral home.
- You may be asked for your loved one's full legal name, date and place of birth, Social Security number and parents' names, plus clothing and photos.

Important documents

- Ask the funeral home for certified copies of the death certificate. Many families need 10 or more.
- Gather records as you are able: identity papers, insurance policies, property titles, bank and tax records, and military discharge papers.

Legal and financial questions

- In time, you may need to contact your loved one's employer, bank, insurers, Social Security, and Veterans Affairs (**800-827-1000**, va.gov).
- An attorney can help with wills, probate and estate questions.

Take these one at a time. We are here whenever you need us.